The Knesset Building - Architectural Highlights

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The Pleunum Wing (original building)

In 1949 during the first year of its existence, the Knesset was housed in several locations in Jerusalem and Tel Aviv, until the Knesset moved to the Froumine House at the city center of Jerusalem in March 1950. The building was meant to serve as a bank, and was adjusted to fit to the needs of the Israeli parliament. The Froumine House was to be a temporary location for the Knesset, but due to the prolonged process of the decision-making in planning and construction of the permanent Knesset building, the Knesset remained in the small-sized building on King George Street for more than 16 years.

Architect Joseph Klarwein was the winner of the 1957 contest for planning the Knesset building on Givat Ram. His initial proposal presented at the contest was ultimately very different than the building that was inaugurated on August 30th 1966. In fact, it was influenced by different architects that were involved in different parts of the planning and construction throughout its nine years, and among them were architect Dov Carmi and his son Ram.

In textbooks written on the Knesset building, it is claimed that the planners intended to build a construction similar to the Greek Acropolis. Those who worked on the building programs before the contest had very little idea on how they wanted the building to look, and the result – an architectural mixture – surprisingly resembled the building of the United States' embassy in Athens. The embassy was designed by the renowned Bauhaus architect Walter Gropius, which was later considered as a specimen of the "International Style."

Klarwein's original model was comprised of a rectangular construction with 20 columns on its front and back, 15 columns on each side, and two internal yards on the eastern and western sides of the plenum hall found at the center of the building. The entrance to the building was to be on its northern front.



Klarwein's model which won the Knesset building planning competition in 1957

The constructed building was square, with 10 columns on all sides, and with no internal yards; the plenum is not at its center, but on its eastern part; and west to the plenum hall there is a reception hall. This hall is named "Chagall State Hall," as it is decorated with art created by the Russian-born Jewish artist, Marc Chagall.

It was decided during the planning period that the entrance to the building will be on its southern side, with a wide stairway that will connect the gates with Ruppin Road. Concerns raised by the General Staff of the military about Jordanian shelling towards the southern side of the Knesset building had brought about the return of the entrance to the building's northern side.

The construction of the Knesset building made wide use of bare concrete, both on the interior and exterior, and one of the engineers was sent abroad specifically to learn the required techniques which were popular at that time during the 1960's. In accordance with the construction regulations of the Jerusalem municipality, the external walls of the building were intertwined with a reddish stone brought from the Galilee. A local reddish stone was found while digging for the foundations of the building, but its quarrying was too slow and expensive, while the use of explosives would have made it useless for purposes of coating. Throughout the years, most of the concrete walls were painted over, and the original concrete can only be seen when looking at the ceiling of the plenum hall.

The interior of the building was decorated by interior decorator Dora Gad. Gad made wide use of wood for covering the walls of the plenum, the committee rooms and a large part of the public areas. She made use of soft colors and only few areas were floored with polished stone, in an attempt to maintain an unpretentious atmosphere. The Chagall Hall was among the few areas to be floored with polished stone, but other areas were also floored in the late 1990's. Other areas that had regular flooring or linoleum flooring were later covered in carpets and parquet floors.

The first Speaker of the Knesset, Joseph Shprinzak, ordered from Chagall mosaics and tapestries. Dora Gad – mostly on her own initiative – ordered different art pieces from Israeli artists and from new immigrants to decorate the Knesset building and surrounding area. Among those artists were Dan Ben Shmuel, Shraga Weil, David Palombo, Hava Kaufmann, Moshe Castel, Dani Karavan, Reuven Rubin and Buky Schwartz.

The Knesset building was inaugurated on August 20th 1966, and the next day the Knesset began to hold sittings therein.

Architecturally, most interesting areas of the original building were the plenum, Chagall State Hall, library, cabinet (government) room and the committee rooms.

The Plenum Hall



The plenum hall during the opening sitting of the Seventeenth Kneset, April 17, 2006

The plenum hall's significant feature is its height of three stories. The Knesset members sit on its lower floor, and in its center is the hoof-shaped government table. Seats of Knesset members who are not members of the government are by the back and sides of the government table. The dais is at the front of the hall, and during plenum sittings it is occupied by the Speaker or one of his deputies, the Secretary General or one of his deputies, and a parliamentary stenographer. Behind the dais is a wall decorated by sculptor Dany Karavan on the theme, "Jerusalem between heaven and earth." The stones that comprise it were chiseled for nine months by local stonemasons under the instruction of Karavan. He also designed the twelve beams hanging from the ceiling of the plenum, after it was decided for acoustic and aesthetic reasons to add them to the high ceiling designed by Klarwein. The original plan was to have natural light come into the plenum from numerous windows placed on the ceiling, but this plan was shelved and the windows were sealed.

The plenum has two galleries: The VIP gallery and the public gallery. The public gallery is shielded by bullet-proof glass ever since an incident that occurred in Froumine House when a mentally disturbed man threw a grenade onto the plenum floor towards the government table.

The original planning included a balcony on the front wall of the plenum for the President of the State, but Karavan claimed it would be more honorable for the President to sit in a concealed corner of the VIP gallery behind a glass wall.

The dome-shaped roof of the plenum underwent a procedure August 2008 to protect it from missiles.



The Knesset's state hall: The Chagall tapestries and the "chocolate" ceiling

Chagall State Hall

The Chagall State Hall is the first area reached upon entering the Knesset through the "Weil Gate" – the main entrance to the Knesset building on the fourth floor. The hall is used for receptions and official events. It is decorated with three tapestries and mosaics designed by the Russian-born Jewish artist Marc Chagall. The themes of the tapestries are adapted from Jewish history: The right tapestry is of the prophetic "Vision of the Final Redemption," the center – "Exodus," and the left – "Return to Zion."

During the planning of the hall, it was suggested that a gallery be built alongside the upper walls, which will be 3 meters wide and serve as a sitting area for members of the Knesset and their visitors. The original construction consisted of approximately 30 chambers for Knesset members, and these sitting areas were to serve as a private gathering place for Knesset members and their guests. The gallery was also to lessen the sense of alienation that was created by the size of the hall. However, Klarwein, who had surrendered on the issue of the high ceiling in the plenum, fought fiercely against this plan. It was eventually decided by Dora Gad, together with Chagall, that the atmosphere at the hall will be softened by installing wooden blocks on the ceiling; this was also not approved by Klarwein, who called the ceiling "an advertisement for chocolate".

Knesset Library

The design of the Knesset library, including its sunken center named “the pool,” was inspired by the library designed by Finnish Architect Alvar Aalto, built in the town of Viipuri during the years 1927 – 1935. His work also inspired other architectural elements in the building, such as the stairway leading from the first to the second floor. The library was changed over the years, including the painting of its concrete columns in cream and the building of a lighting arch, but the basic design remains.



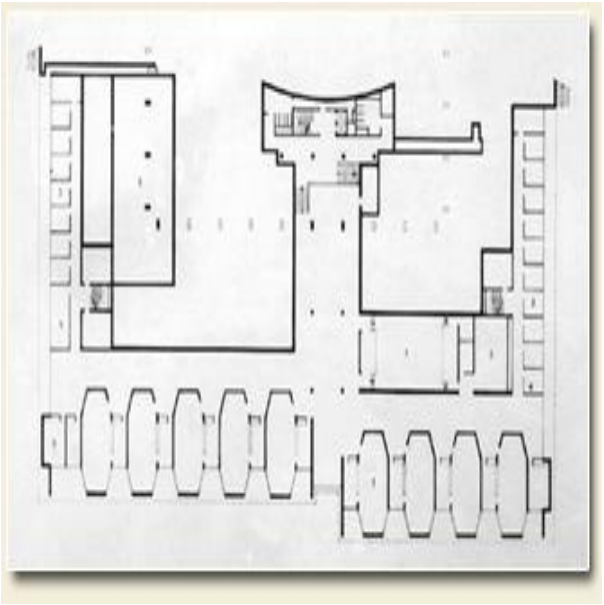
The library designed by Aalto in Viipuri



The original Knesset library, before renovations

Committee Rooms

Committee rooms were originally placed on the first floor, in a terrace-shaped construction on the southern edges of the building. Their windows were positioned at an angle, as the southern wall of the committee rooms was designed as a secured wall, protected from Jordanian shelling. The walls on the northern side of the rooms were also built with similar angles, providing the potato-shaped rooms with a certain softness. The angle of the windows also prevented from those sitting at the head of the table to appear as silhouettes to others in the room. The walls of the rooms were covered in wood panels, designed differently and made of different kinds of wood in each room. The committees were transferred in January 2008 to the new wing, and the old rooms are to be used for other purposes.



Committee floor plan in the original building



Economics Committee room in the original building

Government Room

The Government Room is situated on the second floor of the building. It does not hold the regular cabinet meetings, but serves for holding gatherings of ministers when needed in the Knesset. The room is among the most impressive in the Knesset, despite its small size. Most of space is taken up by the round table made of condensed wood, and each seat is faced with a black leather board for writing. Above the table is a white ceiling which is recessed inwards and

houses within it the lighting system. The floor is covered with a blue carpet and the walls of the room are covered with a bright oak cover. On the wall across from the entrance to the room is a large oil painting of the Galilee by Reuven Rubin.



Government room

Negba Wing



Knesset auditorium

The planning of a new wing to the Knesset building began in 1981, and its construction was consigned to the Department of Public Works. The need for the wing evolved from the decision to provide each Knesset member with an office. Furthermore, Knesset members began hiring secretaries and parliamentary assistants beginning in 1977, new departments were established in the Knesset such as the legal department and the computer department; and older departments expanded in size. There were attempts to resolve overcrowding by closing some open spaces on the second and fourth floors and creating more rooms, but building a new wing eventually became unavoidable.

The new wing was at first nicknamed the “Hilton,” as its narrow carpeted hallways in which 48 chambers were built for Knesset members, resemble hotel corridors. Its construction was finished in 1992.

In addition to the chambers, the new wing also housed an auditorium with 330 seats. The wooden wall behind the auditorium’s stage was designed by artist Dany Karavan. The wing also included storage areas, and until the construction of Kedma Wing, it housed two committee rooms and a gym.

The distinction of Negba is that is largely unnoticed at ground level, as its entrance is through the committee floor in the original building. Its size can only be discerned from aerial photographs.

Kedma Wing

During the term of the Fourteenth Knesset (1996 – 1999), it was decided to extend the Knesset building once again. The growing numbers of Knesset employees and administrative units, the expansion of existing departments, and the growing number of visitors – these required a permanent solution. Over the years, caravans were placed on the eastern side of the building, which were later transferred to the western side when construction began and then removed at its completion. The growing number of visitors required a new setting for security checks at the entrance and brought about the need to move the committees from the first floor on the southern side: The main entrance to the building is placed on the fourth floor on its northern side, generating considerable maintenance needs for the public areas and the elevators.

The tender for the construction of the new wing was publicized in the year 2000 during the Fifteenth Knesset. It was granted to the local architects' office of Guy Meltzer and Guy Igra. Their plan included an underground parking lot, a new entrance to the Knesset, a new wing to be built across the eastern side of the original building – connected to it through various passes, and a building for maintenance facilities. A visitors' wing was also planned, but it was withdrawn during the Seventeenth Knesset.



A committee room in the Kedma wing

During the planning of the new wing it had to be taken into account that the Knesset must carry on with its work. This factor was integrated into the execution of the construction as, for example, the parking lot and machine rooms were first demolished first while the underground parking and energy-maintenance center were built next, before the construction of the new chambers and committee rooms.

The construction of Kedma wing was completed in stages between November 2005 and January 2008, and it doubled the square footage of the Knesset. The northern part of the wing is a three-story high building with 17 spacious and technologically equipped meeting rooms, chambers for 16 of the committee chairpersons, and offices for the committees' staffs. The rooms for the 12 standing committees are elliptic, and there are two additional round committee rooms.

The view seen out of the windows on the eastern side of the building is of the Rehavia and Nahlahot neighborhoods of Jerusalem.

The center building of the wing is two-stories high and has 49 chambers for Knesset members and several smaller conference rooms. The southern building is a one-story building that houses administrative offices, including those of the legal department, the research and information center, the computer department, and the gym.

The Kedma wing is built mostly above ground-level, but it does not overshadow the original building. The familiar silhouette of the Knesset remains visible from all directions.



Committee building in the Kedma wing

The building style is modern and spacious, and it does not pretend to copy the original style of the building, though they are organically integrated. Many of the public areas in the new building have round walls, there is much use of stone, and bare concrete is only found on its external columns.

The wing was built around seven internal courtyards, and so it is lighted throughout the day with soft natural lighting. The courtyards contain richly planted gardens and archaeological exhibits. For example, a 2,000 year-old burial ground was found in one of the yards, which was known to have existed but was only exposed during the construction. It was decided during the planning of the new wing, mostly due to financial reasons, that Kedma will not be decorated by works of art. Rather, archaeological findings are used for its decoration.



Aerial view of the Knesset following its extension. The photo was taken from the west.